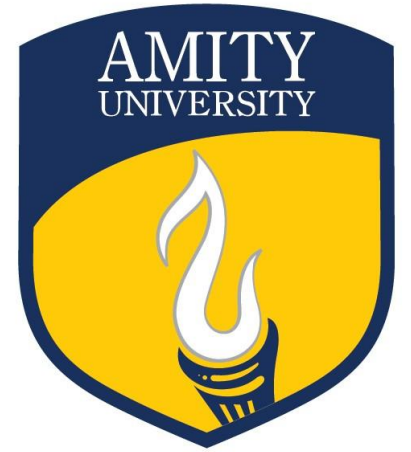


Amity University, Noida



Finland's Education System

A Comparative Analysis for Curriculum Studies



Knowledge and Curriculum (B.Ed.) — Department of Education

A COMPARATIVE STUDY

Presented by
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Academic Year 2025-2027
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Finland's Education System

— A Comprehensive Analysis for Curriculum Studies

Excellence Through Equity



Mirror, Not Model



KEY FOCUS

Curriculum Design



ANALYSIS

Finland-India



MODEL

Global Reform

The Finnish Paradox – Excellence Through Equity

🚫 What Finland Doesn't Have

- ✗ Standardized testing
- ✗ School inspections
- ✗ School rankings
- ✗ Private competition
- ✗ Performance pay
- ✗ Excessive homework

Four Pillars of the Finnish Model



Equity

Fair access for all



Formative Assessment

Feedback for learning



Teacher Quality

Highly qualified professionals



Holistic Curriculum

Designed for life, not tests

Significance for Curriculum Studies



Curriculum matters

- Design shapes classroom reality



Teachers matter most • No curriculum exceeds teacher capacity



Context matters • Adaptation not adoption



Time matters • Systemic change requires decades

Context: Geographical, Socio-Cultural & Historical



Nordic Welfare State Foundation



Geographical Challenges

18

people/km²

180K+

lakes

86%

forest cover



Harsh climate & long winters



Dispersed settlements across vast distances



Nordic Welfare State



Consensus & trust culture



Social cohesion & equity focus



Universal healthcare & education



Strong labor protections



Historical Evolution

Pre-70s Dual-track system

1968-77 Comprehensive school reform

1980s Decentralization & trust

1990s Teacher education enhancement

2000s+ Student welfare & PhBL

Educational Pathway: From ECEC to Higher Education



ECEC

Ages 0-6

- Play-based learning
- Qualified teachers
- Early intervention



Pre-Primary

Age 6 • 1 Year

- School readiness
- Assessment before schooling
- Compulsory since 2015



Comprehensive

7-16 Years • 9 Years

- No tracking/streaming
- No national exams
- Free meals & transport



Upper Secondary

16-19 Years • 3 Years

General (Lukio)

Academic • Matriculation exam

Vocational

Practical skills • Workplace learning

Parity of esteem • Students can switch tracks



Higher Education

19+ Years



Universities

Research-focused • Academic



UAS

Practice-oriented • Applied

Comprehensive School (Peruskoulu)



9 Years • All Students Together

⊘ **No Tracking or Streaming**
Mixed-ability teaching for all students

⚙️ **Multi-Tiered Support System**

- 1 **General**
Short-term interventions
- 2 **Intensified**
Regular long-term support
- 3 **Special**
Individualized support

🏠 **Free Services**

- 🍴 Free meals
- 📚 Learning materials
- 🏥 Healthcare
- 🚌 Transportation

👥 **Support Teams**

- 🧠 Student welfare teams
- 🎓 Guidance counseling
- 🦷 Dental care
- ✅ No national exams

Upper Secondary & Higher Education

Upper Secondary

16-19 Years • 3 Years

General (Lukio)

-  Subject-based with increasing choice
-  Matriculation Examination
-  Academic preparation for university

Vocational

-  Competence-based learning
-  Workplace learning emphasis
-  Eligibility for higher education

Parity of esteem • Students can switch tracks • No dead ends

Higher Education

19+ Years • Dual Model

Universities

-  Research-focused orientation
-  Academic degrees (Bachelor, Master, Doctoral)
-  Selective admission process

Universities of Applied Sciences

-  Practice-oriented education
-  Professional degrees (Bachelor, Master)
-  Applied research & development

National Curriculum: Evolution, Structure & Values

~ Curriculum Evolution

- 70s Centralized, content-based
- 80s Decentralization begins
- 90s Competence orientation
- 00s Holistic development
- 14+ Phenomenon-based learning

◆ Three-Tiered Structure

- ↓ National Core Curriculum
- ↓ Municipal Curriculum
- ↓ School-Level Curriculum
- ↓ Teacher's Annual Plan

♥ Core Values Underpinning the Curriculum



Human Dignity

Inclusive practices



Equity

Fair access for all



Democracy

Participation & voice



Sustainability

Ecological responsibility



Cultural Diversity

Respect for multiple identities • Multilingual awareness • Inclusivity

Curriculum Content: Subjects, Competencies & PhBL



💡 Phenomenon-Based Learning

Investigating real-world phenomena from multiple disciplinary perspectives • At least one multidisciplinary module annually

📖 Subject Structure (199 Lessons)

56

Mother Tongue

29

Mathematics

23

Languages

30

Arts & PE

13

Environmental

12

Sciences

9

Religion/Ethics

7

Other

⚙️ Seven Transversal Competencies

T1

Thinking

Metacognition

T2

Cultural

Communication

T3

Self-care

Well-being

T4

Multiliteracy

Texts & media

T5

ICT Skills

Digital use

T6

Working Life

Entrepreneurship

T7

Participation

Sustainable future

Teacher Education & Professional Autonomy



Rigorous Selection

10% acceptance rate • Multi-stage assessment



Research-Based Master's

Mandatory for all teachers • University programs



Professional Autonomy

- ✓ No routine inspections
- ✓ Freedom in methods
- ✓ Choice of materials



Collaborative Culture

- ✓ Team planning
- ✓ Peer observation
- ✓ Multi-professional teams



Teachers as Curriculum Developers

Interpret framework • Adapt locally • Design learning experiences • Evaluate practice

Assessment System Overview

Low-stakes, High-trust Model • Assessment for Learning

Formative Assessment

- ✓ **Continuous Feedback**
Ongoing, detailed guidance
- ✓ **Descriptive Comments**
Narrative reports over grades
- ✓ **Teacher Autonomy**
Design own assessments
- ✓ **No School Rankings**
Collaboration over competition

Reduces anxiety • Encourages risk-taking

Matriculation Exam

Sole High-Stakes Test

At age 18, end of upper secondary school

Purpose

Evaluate intellectual development • Certify readiness for higher education

Results

For student, not school ranking

University Admission

One factor among many • Universities conduct own entrance tests

Performance & Strengths of the Finnish Model

PISA 2024 Scores

Mathematics	484
Reading	490
Science	511

KEY INDICATOR: Equity

Between-School Variance:

5%	25%	40%+
Finland	OECD Avg	India

Socio-Economic Impact

Minimal influence on outcomes

Seven Strengths of the Model

-  **Philosophical Coherence**
Values-embedded curriculum
-  **Teacher Professionalism**
Curriculum developers
-  **Flexibility**
Framework approach adaptable locally
-  **Holistic Orientation**
Balance across all domains
-  **Future-Orientation**
Competency-based preparation
-  **Equity Focus**
Universal design for all
-  **Innovation**
Phenomenon-based learning

Finland demonstrates that **equity + quality** can coexist without traditional competitive measures

Finland vs India: Curriculum Philosophy & Structure

Finland

Purpose

Holistic development • Democratic citizenship • Life preparation

Orientation

Competence-based • Phenomenon-focused • Transversal competencies

Values

Nordic welfare state • Equity • Democracy • Sustainability

Teacher Role

Autonomous curriculum developer • High professionalism

Framework

NCC • Municipal & school adaptation

Integrated Learning

PhBL mandatory • Multidisciplinary modules

India

Purpose

Holistic development • 21st century skills • Indian knowledge systems

Orientation

Competency-based • Learning outcomes-focused • Essential competencies

Values

Constitutional values • Indian traditions • Cultural heritage

Teacher Role

Empowered pedagogical facilitator • Developing professionalism

Framework

NCF • State & local flexibility

Integrated Learning

Interdisciplinary projects encouraged • Cross-curricular competencies

Policy Lessons for India: From Principle to Practice

Teacher Education

- ✓ 4-year ITEP with curriculum studies
- ✓ University-affiliated demo schools
- ✓ Continuous professional development
- ✓ Research orientation in preparation

Assessment Reform

- ✓ Reduce syllabus content for depth
- ✓ Redesign board exams for competencies
- ✓ Develop school-leaving profiles
- ✓ Multiple measures vs single exam

Local Curriculum

- ✓ Build state/district capacity
- ✓ Develop exemplar curricula
- ✓ Allocate teacher collaboration time
- ✓ Empower teachers as developers

PhBL Adaptation

- ✓ Start gradually (1/year)
- ✓ Build teacher capacity
- ✓ Develop resource materials
- ✓ Connect to local issues

Address Equity

- ✓ Strengthen foundational layer (nutrition, health)
- ✓ Target resources to disadvantaged schools
- ✓ Create equity in materials
- ✓ Recognize schools must compensate deficits

What India Can and Cannot Learn from Finland

✔ Adaptable Principles

- ✔ **Trust as Foundation**
Build through capacity development
- ✔ **Teacher Quality**
Invest in education, selection, support
- ✔ **Less is More**
Reduce syllabus, prioritize depth over coverage
- ✔ **Formative Assessment**
Learning improves with feedback, not rankings
- ✔ **Flexible Pathways**
No dead ends, parity between tracks
- ✔ **Phenomenon-Based Learning**
Engages students, develops competencies

❌ Contextual Limitations

- ❌ **Cultural Specificity**
Trust requires homogeneity, difficult to replicate
- ❌ **Resource Intensity**
Small classes, extensive support require investment
- ❌ **Declining PISA Performance**
Questions whether innovations deliver outcomes
- ❌ **Multicultural Adaptation**
Designed for homogeneous society, needs negotiation

Finland is a **mirror for reflection**, not a model for replication

Finland as **Mirror**, Not Model



Offers **principles**, not blueprints



Success rests on **decades of capacity-building**



Implementation matters more than policy vision



Context must shape adaptation



Trust earned through **competence**, not granted



Time is essential for systemic change

Curriculum must serve **all students**, not just elites